

THE NHS CONSTITUTION

The NHS belongs to us all. It touches our lives at times of basic human need, when care and compassion are what matter most. Pregnancy is one of these times. So it is important that you know what you and your baby can expect from the NHS, and what is expected from you in return.



The NHS Constitution was launched on 21 January 2009. It brings together for the first time in one place what staff, patients and the public can expect from the NHS. It explains that by working together we can make the very best of finite resources to improve our health and well-being, to keep our minds and bodies well, to get better when we are ill, and when we cannot recover to stay as well as we can to the end of our lives. The Constitution reaffirms that everyone has a role to play in the success of the NHS.

As well as capturing what is important to the NHS (the principles and values that determine how the NHS should act and make decisions), the Constitution brings together a number of rights, pledges and responsibilities for staff and patients alike.

These rights, pledges and responsibilities are the result of extensive discussion and research with staff, patients and the public and they reflect what matters to them most.

Rights

The NHS Constitution sets out the legal rights of the public, patients and staff. Some of the rights that may be of interest to you are listed below:

- **You have the right** to receive NHS services free of charge, unless Parliament has sanctioned charges.
- **You have the right** to be treated with dignity and respect.
- **You have the right** to be treated with a professional standard of care.
- **You have the right** to be given information about your care.
- **You have the right** to privacy and confidentiality.
- **You have the right** to be involved in discussions and decisions about your care.
- **You have the right** to have any complaints you make properly investigated.



Pledges

The NHS Constitution sets out a number of pledges for the public, patients and staff. These are things that the **NHS is committed to achieving**. Some of the pledges that may be of interest to you are listed below:

- **The NHS commits** to make sure that it is easy to access health services.
- **The NHS commits** to inform you about the services that are available to you.
- **The NHS commits** to offer you information that helps you to take part in making decisions about your care.
- **The NHS commits** to work in partnership with you, your family, carers and representatives.
- **The NHS commits** to treat you with courtesy and to be supportive when you make a complaint.

Responsibilities

There are a number of things we can all do to help the NHS deliver quality services. These are set out as responsibilities in the NHS Constitution. Responsibilities are the things **we can all do to help the NHS work effectively**. You should always think about your responsibilities when you are receiving NHS services. You have nine responsibilities to keep in mind:

- Do what you can yourself to stay healthy and feel well.
- Register with a GP.
- Treat NHS staff and patients with respect.
- Give accurate information about yourself.
- Keep appointments, or let the NHS know when you cannot keep them.
- Follow the course of your treatment, or speak to someone if you feel you cannot.
- Take part in important public health immunisation programmes.
- Make sure people close to you know about your wishes for organ donation.
- Give feedback on your treatment and care.

The NHS Constitution sets out all of these rights and pledges, together with the principles and values, in more detail. The NHS Constitution Handbook contains further information.



Want to know more?

The **NHS Constitution Handbook** gives further information about the NHS Constitution and further advice on what to do if you are not happy with the service you receive. The **Statement of NHS Accountability** summarises how the NHS is structured and what the responsibilities of individual parts of the NHS are.

How do I get a copy of the NHS Constitution?

You can get copies of the NHS Constitution from libraries, doctors, dentists and town halls. You can also obtain a copy from:

Telephone:

0300 123 1002

Website:

www.orderline.dh.gov.uk

Email:

dh@prolog.uk.com

Or write to:

DH Publications Orderline

PO Box 777

London SE1 6XH

The NHS Constitution, NHS Constitution Handbook and the Statement of NHS Accountability are also available online at **www.nhs.uk/aboutnhs/Constitution**

